

NBA

# Anthony Mason suffers ‘massive heart attack’

By [Fred Kerber](#)

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Anthony Mason, the self-proclaimed “Locksmith” whose defense and bruising play became a staple of the Pat Riley Knicks teams in the 1990s, is critically ill following a massive heart attack, a person familiar with the situation confirmed Wednesday.

Mason, 48, played with the Knicks for five seasons from 1991 to 1996, averaging 9.9 points and 7.7 rebounds during his time in New York.

While the team issued no official comment, the Knicks tweeted out before



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Former Post NBA columnist Peter Vecsey first reported the sobering news on Twitter.



"Sickened 2 report, ex-Knick Anthony Mason fighting 4 life. Congestive heart failure, heart attack, 4 surgeries, last one 9 hrs. Sons by side," Vecsey tweeted.

Vecsey later added Mason suffered the heart attack while at the hospital for tests, noting the former All-Star player's weight had skyrocketed to 350 pounds, roughly 90 pounds above his playing weight. Mason had been dealing with heart issues for a year, the tweet said.

Linking to Vecsey's tweet, former Knicks great Mark Jackson offered, "Praying for my former teammate Anthony Mason!!!"

Mason played 13 seasons in the league, averaging 10.9 points and 8.3 rebounds. He missed the 1998-99 season with a ruptured biceps while a member of the Charlotte Hornets. He was the league's Sixth Man of the Year with the Knicks in 1995 and an All-Star with the Heat in 2001.

Mason's bruising, take-no-prisoners style endeared him to both Knicks fans and Riley, who kept the powerful, 6-foot-7, 260-pound forward as a virtual walk-on in 1991. Mason gave himself the nickname "Locksmith" because, "Put me on anybody and I'll lock 'em up" defensively.

Even after he retired, Mason stayed around the Knicks. In 2007, he was a frequent visitor to the team practice facility, where he served as an unofficial big-man coach for Eddy Curry, with whom he worked frequently.

Mason was born in Miami, but he went to school in Springfield Gardens, Queens. After playing collegiately at Tennessee State, Mason was drafted on the third round by Portland but was cut. He played briefly overseas in 1988-89.

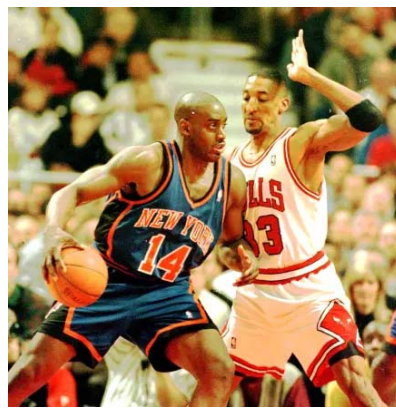
Mason made pit stops in New Jersey and Denver and played in the CBA, where he was scouted by, among others, scout Fuzzy Levane for the Knicks. He received an invitation to the Knicks summer league team in Riley's first season in New York.

In 1991, before heading to Los Angeles for the LA Summer League, the Knicks played two games in what then was called their Summer Caravan at Kutcher's in Monticello in Sullivan County. In two games, Mason played with staggering, brutish force. Riley spoke of him as one would a bulldozer. He was signed before the Knicks made it to LA.

Mason was also a gifted passer, another trait which caught Riley's eye.

But Mason also was critical of the offense's perceived over-reliance on Patrick Ewing. A benching after halftime one night during the 1993-94 season led to more unhappiness — and a suspension imposed by Riley for the final two games of that regular season. Mason, though, was reinstated for the playoff and the Knicks went to the Finals, losing to Houston in seven games.

Mason was traded to Charlotte in a deal for Larry Johnson in July 1996. He was reunited with Riley in Miami in 2000 in a deal that brought Eddie Jones with him while P.J. Brown and Jamal Mashburn were among those headed to Charlotte.



Anthony Mason was known for his rugged play on offense and defense.  
WA Funches Jr.

Mason's son, Anthony Jr., played at St. John's while son Antoine currently is at Auburn.

*Former Knick Anthony Mason was hospitalized Wednesday after suffering a heart attack. Here's a glimpse at some of the ups & downs of his turbulent life and career:*

### Highs

- Born Dec. 14, 1966, in Miami.
- Drafted 53rd overall in 1988 by the Trail Blazers.
- Spent 1989-90 season with the Nets and 1990-91 season. with the Nuggets before signing with Knicks as free agent before 1991-92 season.
- Played five seasons for the Knicks, averaging 11.2 points and 8.8 rebounds per game.
- Earned Sixth Man of the Year award during 1994-95 season, averaging 9.4 points and 8.1 rebounds.
- Finished his career playing three seasons with the Hornets, one season with the Heat, and two seasons with the Bucks.

### Lows

- In 2011, it was revealed he owed the state of Wisconsin \$2.07 million in back taxes.
- In 2000, he was arrested and charged with third-degree assault for his role in a bar fight in Harlem.
- In 1998, he was charged with statutory rape in Queens, and entered into a plea agreement for a lesser charge. Sentenced to 200 hours of community service.
- In 1996, he was accused of fighting with police in Times Square over a parking ticket and allegedly attacked a patron in a Manhattan restaurant. The patron sued him.

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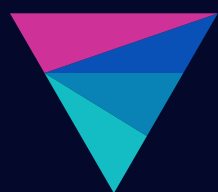
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